

Name: _____

Period: _____

Date: _____

Topic 1.2 Guided Notes: Overview of the Nervous System

Unit 1: Biological Bases of Behavior | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appspsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic1.2

Word Bank

<i>Peripheral Nervous System</i>	<i>Autonomic Nervous System</i>	<i>Somatic Nervous System</i>
<i>Central Nervous System</i>	<i>Parasympathetic Nervous System</i>	<i>Sympathetic Nervous System</i>

1. The Command Center: The Central Nervous System

The _____ is the division of the nervous system consisting of the brain and spinal cord, which processes information and coordinates the body's responses — your body's primary computer.

2. The Branches: The Peripheral Nervous System

The _____ consists of the sensory and motor neurons that connect the central nervous system to the rest of the body — any neuron that isn't inside your skull or spinal column belongs here.

- _____: the division of the peripheral nervous system that controls the body's skeletal muscles (voluntary movements) — like deliberately raising your hand or kicking a soccer ball.
- _____: the division of the peripheral nervous system that automatically regulates involuntary body functions such as heartbeat, breathing, digestion, and gland activity.

Apply It: Voluntary or Involuntary?

Using the word bank above, identify which division of the peripheral nervous system is responsible for each action.

#	Scenario	Division
1	A drummer deliberately taps out a rhythm with his sticks.	
2	A sleeping infant's lungs continue expanding and contracting on their own.	
3	A student consciously raises her hand to answer a question in class.	

3. Involuntary Control: Sympathetic vs. Parasympathetic

The Autonomic Nervous System's job changes dramatically depending on whether you're facing a crisis or relaxing — it splits into two opposing subsystems that are heavily tested on the AP exam.

- _____: activates the body's "fight-or-flight" response during stress or danger — accelerating heartbeat, dilating pupils, expanding lungs, and slowing digestion to prepare for action.
- _____: calms the body and conserves energy by promoting "rest-and-digest" functions after a stressful situation — slowing the heart, constricting pupils, and restarting digestion.

Apply It: Fight-or-Flight or Rest-and-Digest?

#	Scenario	System
1	A student's palms sweat and heart pounds right before walking on stage to give a speech.	
2	After finishing a big meal, a person feels calm and drowsy as their body focuses on digesting.	
3	A driver slams the brakes to avoid a car accident, pupils wide and pulse racing.	

4. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

_____ is for voluntary skeletal muscle control (think "Soma" = body, and you choose how to move your body). _____ is for involuntary visceral control (think "Autonomic" = automatic).

Exam tip: if a scenario involves a racing heart, sweaty palms, or public speaking anxiety, look for the _____. If it involves relaxing on the couch, sleeping, or recovering from a scare, look for the _____.

5. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. A pianist consciously decides to move her fingers across the keys to play a specific song. Which division of the nervous system directly carries this voluntary command to her skeletal muscles?

- A. Parasympathetic Nervous System
- B. Central Nervous System
- C. Autonomic Nervous System
- D. Somatic Nervous System

2. A student doesn't consciously think about digesting her lunch or regulating her heartbeat while she takes a nap; these processes simply happen automatically in the background. Which division of the nervous system is responsible for this automatic regulation?
- A. Autonomic Nervous System
 - B. Somatic Nervous System
 - C. Sympathetic Nervous System Only
 - D. Central Nervous System
3. While hiking, a woman suddenly encounters a rattlesnake. Her heart immediately races, her pupils dilate, and her digestion slows as her body prepares to react to the danger. Which system is responsible for this reaction?
- A. Sympathetic Nervous System
 - B. Central Nervous System
 - C. Parasympathetic Nervous System
 - D. Somatic Nervous System
4. A person is fully relaxed on the couch, breathing slowly, with a low resting heart rate, and easily digesting a recent meal. Which system is primarily active during this state?
- A. Parasympathetic Nervous System
 - B. Central Nervous System Only
 - C. Somatic Nervous System
 - D. Sympathetic Nervous System



Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the [Quiz](https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz) to test what you've learned:

<https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz>